

**First Congregational Church of Los Angeles**  
**Fall Series 4**  
*Painting the Stars ~ An Anticipatory Universe*  
**13 September 2026**

**LVF Updated 4 September 4pm**  
*Needs Communion Liturgy and Lord's Prayer*

**COMMUNION**  
**Preaching: LVF**  
**Worship Leading: ML and ...**

**Organ Prelude-Concert**

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

**Chiming of the Hour**

**[ to center chancel]**

**Welcome**

**Words of Gathering**

In the beginning was a sound, a silence,  
a consonant, a vowel,  
a mumble, a sigh,  
a shout.

In the beginning was an idea,  
a possibility, an urge and an urgency,  
a compulsion, a wonder,  
a love.

In the beginning was the Word,  
the Creation, the Articulation,  
the Invitation, the Choice,  
the Name, the Yes.

This morning as we worship the God of all language and nuance,  
we pray that our hearts will break open to the new beginnings  
that surround us in this sacred space. [rhackenberg]

***Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering***

**[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]**

**\*Hymn Of Gathering**

*Joyful, Joyful, We Adore Thee*

**[... center chancel]**

**Prayer of Awareness**

God of Creativity,  
whose renewing breath fills our planet,  
may we discover your vibrant, creative presence among us.  
On this day, may our spirits be lifted as we celebrate  
with the clouds, the winds, the dusk, and the dawn.

And then, O God, as we stand in awe  
before the vast reaches of space above us,  
may we give thanks for this fragile piece of stardust  
we call Earth.

May it be so.

*May it be so for al of us.*

*Amen and Amen!*

**[All turn towards choir]**

**Introit**

**[ to lectern]**

**\*The Lord's Prayer**

**Let us pray together this Lord's Prayer, adapted by enfleshed...**

**[All turn towards altar]**

**\*Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,  
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.  
World without end, Amen, Amen.

**[ center chancel]**

**\*Passing of the Peace**

The peace of the morning's stillness  
the peace of new beginnings  
the peace of heaven's kiss  
to welcome us to this day  
to root us in this day  
to free us for this day

that we may grow with the greening earth  
that we may grow from the ground of glory  
that we may grow in grateful wonder of You  
Gracious Giver of this day  
Great Giver of this day. [jphilipnewell]  
This morning, may the peace of God be with you.  
***And also with you!***

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.  
***And also with you!***

***You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow***

***Please be seated***

**[ to lectern]**

**Reading from Our Religious Tradition *from Genesis 1***  
*Listen now to this reading from Genesis 1 found in a paraphrase  
by the Celtic Theologian, J. Philip Newell.*

In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth.  
Before that there was only empty darkness and the deep  
eternal waters.  
But in the dark, a wind began to stir.  
It was the breath of life.  
It was God saying, 'Let there be light.'  
And there was light.  
God saw that it was good.  
There was a time for light and a time for darkness.  
The light was called day and the darkness night.  
And there was evening and morning, creation's first day.

This is the witness of the ancients...  
***Thanks be to God!***

**[Christoph transition ... to center chancel]**

**Prayers with the People**

**Invitation to Silence and Prayer**

**[2 minutes of silence, then Emma transition out of silence]**

### **Prayer of Our Hearts**

Gracious God, how often our names for you  
fail to describe your majesty and mystery.  
When we think we have captured your essence,  
another realm appears,  
reminding us you are beyond  
all language and image.  
You speckle the ink-dark night with your star-writing,  
you soften the sun-stark day with your cloud brush.

Our minds can barely comprehend –  
the ways in which you continue to work  
with the single-celled to the infinitely-complex creatures,  
as you continually create and re-create.

You speak slyly from inside the bosons  
and stride boldly beyond the galaxies.

You cannot, must not, will not be contained  
by our meager words and skewed vision,  
yet you answer our cries, not matter the name we use.

*Teach us, Eternal One,  
to work beyond the bounds of our labels and language.  
Help us to leave the comfort of our narrow images.  
Remind us that you are All in All  
and that no matter who we are,  
or where we reside -  
you are with us  
in all space and time.  
Amen and Amen!*

[JerryHebenstreit/adaptlvf]

**[Christoph transition for Choir]**

**Meditation Anthem**

**[Christoph transition Laura to pulpit]**

**Sermon**

*An Anticipatory Universe*

**LVF**

**[Christoph transition as Michael & Laura go behind communion table]**

**The Eucharist and Blessings**

## **Words of Invitation and Remembrance**

You are welcome at this table if you have a little faith, a lot of faith, absolutely no faith, or are of another faith. This is the Table of the Christ, and the welcome is wide!

### **Sharing of the Bread and the Cup**

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

**[... to lectern]**

### **Invitation to Generosity**

The writer J. Philip Newell believes  
our times of religious observation  
and meditative practice  
are not merely alternatives to encountering God  
in the ever-flowing stream of life.  
We need both...every day.

When we come to this place each week,  
we are given an opportunity to prepare ourselves  
to be alert to the One who is always and everywhere present,  
closer to us than we are to ourselves.

We do not have to go to the farthest reaches of the universe to find God.  
God is here with us – God is everywhere with us.

In gratitude for the light we are given in this life,  
we now offer our tithes, our gifts, and ourselves  
as our morning offerings are given and received.

### **Offertory**

**[All turn towards altar]**

#### **\*Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,  
let the Creator's praise arise!  
Alleluia! Alleluia!  
Your name shall sound and praises soar

till suns shall rise and set no more.  
Alleluia! Alleluia!  
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

**[Megan to lectern]**

**\*Prayer of Offering**

Eternal God, we pray aware that you,  
who are at work  
in the vastness of this universe  
for billions of years,  
will now come to visible  
and audible expression  
in and through these offerings.

With appreciation in our hearts,  
we rejoice, O God,  
that you breath life and vitality  
into our world,  
into our lives,  
and into our gathering here,  
connecting us on the deepest level  
with all that exists.

*For this and so much more,  
we offer our thanks on this day.  
Amen and Amen!*

*Please be seated*

**[Michael and Laura center chancel]**

**Life at First Church**

**ML**

**Words of Blessing**

**LVF**

**Choral Response**

**[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]**

**\*Hymn for the Journey**

*When in Awe of God's Creation*

**HYFRYDOL**

**OR**

*Wake Now My Senses*

**[Michael center chancel]**

## **Postlude**

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

## **Inside The Music**